



AMD acquires SeaMicro

In a bid to get in on the fast growing low-power server market, AMD announced a deal to acquire SeaMicro <http://dgit.in/GMiiZO>

Babel Fish, anyone?

Microsoft's prototype universal speech translator software translates words into another language <http://dgit.in/GLPBjL>

Motherboard Comparison

HOW WE TESTED

We believe that a motherboard performance is completely a function of its components. The higher specced the components, the better performance you will get. For a same chipset, the variation in scores is not much as will be evident from our scores. This can be easily understood by the fact that benchmark scores from a ₹15,000 board are very close to the benchmark scores from a ₹30,000 motherboard, give or take 5 percent.

So, it ultimately boils down to the feature set you are getting with the motherboard, the build quality, ease of overclocking, and other factors. Keeping this in mind, we decided to not give any weightage to the performance scores. We have run benchmarks, and we have all the

scores with us, which we will share. But in our final evaluation, we have not considered these scores as that does not give you an estimation of the motherboard's value.

Our Test Rig comprised of the following components:

- **Processor:** Intel Core i7-3960X
- **SSD:** Kingston HyperX 240GB
- **RAM:** 4x4GB Kingston HyperX RAM @ 1333MHz at 9-9-9-24
- **Cooler:** Asetek liquid cooler (Intel Stock)
- **Graphics Card:** ASUS HD 7970
- **Power Supply:** Cooler Master SPH 1050W
- **OS:** Windows 7 Ultimate x64

We ran the benchmarks and logged the scores for pure reference purposes. As you will see

there is not much of a difference as the chipset is the same.

The layout of the board was scored, we checked if there was enough spacing around the CPU region to comfortably attach the CPU cooler and which way the SATA ports were pointing. We also noted the spacing between PCIe slots. If a dual slot card blocked the next PCIe slot, marks were deducted.

For build quality we noted the sturdiness of the heat sinks around the VRM regions and southbridge. Board with all solid state capacitors got a higher score. Back panel I/O ports were noted and also the option to expand USB ports. Number of fan connectors and SATA connections were noted.

Overclocking is one of the key aspects of the X79 chipset based boards. So features such as utilities, on-board chip additions, were taken into consideration. A board having more options to overclock and tweak got a higher score. We indulged in minor overclocking on air. The levels we reached are just an indication to ease of overclocking and should not be considered as the maximum limit. Also the BIOS user experience was noted.

We did a thorough checking and testing (wherever applicable) of the feature set offered by a motherboard and based on the price have decided on the final winners in different categories.

settings, CPU settings among others from your OS.

Biostar Tpower X79 board was the only one which had bright colours on the DIMM and PCIe slots. Aesthetically, it looks very similar to the Tpower Z68 board we had tested sometime back with similar multi-finned heatsinks. It only sports four DIMM slots and comes with three PCIe x16 slots allowing you to do 3-way SLI/ CrossfireX. The SATA port sticking upwards is undesirable and we doubt if it can be used when the first PCIe slot is populated with a longish card.

The Intel DX79SI is the reference X79 board from Intel. It

still sports the older BIOS system which requires just the use of the keyboard. It has PCIe 3.0 slots and there is very little gap between the 8-pin power connector and the VRM heatsink. It does have interesting heat-sink design on the Southbridge and we were impressed with the dual gigabit LAN ports on offer, dedicated power, reset buttons and a POST error readout.

Considering the ECS X79R-AX Extreme is the highest end board from ECS, we were surprised to find only four DIMM slots, whereas even some mid-range X79 boards from competing brands offer eight DIMM

slots. There are around 12 SATA ports, dedicated power, reset buttons along with a POST error

The heatsink over the VRM and southbridge have a temperature sensitive colour sticker which



ASRock X79 Extreme 6/GB

code LED and four PCIe slots with the grey ones running at x16 and white ones at x8 speeds.

changes colour based on the temperature. Just behind the 24-pin power connector, you

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